

People

The Brazilian people have a wide ethnic background, and there are large groups of African, European, and Asian origin. The original inhabitants of Brazil form only a tiny percentage of the population. Many families are tight knit, fiercely loyal, and strict Roman Catholics. The majority live in towns clustered along the southeastern coast.



Indian groups

Some native Brazilians still live in the rainforests, following traditional ways of life. However, about 14 groups now shelter in Xingu National Park, set up when their forest home was destroyed.



20 per sq km
(52 per sq mile)



81% Urban
19% Rural

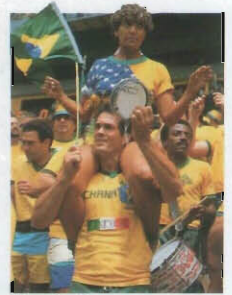
Leisure

The mainly Roman Catholic people of Brazil celebrate many religious festivals, such as the Rio and Bahia carnivals. Sports, including football, basketball, and water sports along the coast, are the chief leisure activities for millions of Brazilians. The samba, one of the world's most popular dances, originated in Brazil.



Rio Carnival

Known as one of the world's largest and most spectacular festivals, the Rio Carnival, in Rio de Janeiro, is held just before Lent every year. During the carnival, processions of brightly decorated floats, and a myriad of colourful singers, musicians, and dancers with imaginative costumes, fill the streets.



Football

Many Brazilians have a passion for football, either as players or spectators. The national team has won the World Cup more times than any other team. Its star player, Edson Arantes do Nascimento, known as Pelé, was the world's leading player in the 1960s and is regarded by fans as a living legend.

Farming

Brazil has immense natural resources. About 22 per cent of the labour force works on the land, growing all Brazil's own food, with a vast surplus for export. The best farmland is around Rio de Janeiro and São Paulo, where water is plentiful and the climate is frost-free. About 150 million cattle are reared on large ranches in this region.



Cattle ranch, São Paulo



Soya beans

Each berry contains two beans, which are washed, dried, and roasted.

Meat production

Brazil is one of the world's largest producers of beef and veal. Cows graze on the rich, green pastures of central Brazil. Large areas of tropical rainforest are cleared to create new cattle ranches, but the soil is soon exhausted and more forest has to be felled.

Crops

Brazil is a leading producer of cocoa beans, coffee, oranges, and sugar-cane, and one of the world's largest growers of soya beans and bananas. About 22 per cent of the world's coffee comes from Brazil, and millions of oranges are picked every year. These crops grow successfully in the warm, fertile soils of central and southern Brazil.



Bananas

Orange



Coffee leaves and berries



Forest products

The plants and trees of the Amazonian rainforest have long been used for food, housing, and medicine by the people who live there. Some of these, such as rubber and Brazil nuts, are now known world-wide. Other lesser-known plants are quinine, taken from chinchona bark and used to treat malaria; ipecacuanha, an ingredient of cough medicines; and curare, once part of an arrow poison, now a life-saving muscle relaxant used in operations.



Brazil nuts



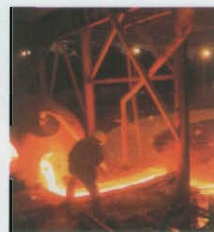
Transport

A vast network links Brazil's main centres, but of the 1,660,352 km (1,031,693 miles) of roads, only nine per cent are paved. Brazil has one of the world's largest national air networks. Cities with rapid growth, such as São Paulo, are expanding their subways.



Mining

Brazil is a leading producer of gold, manganese, and tin ore. The country is noted for its precious stones, such as amethysts, diamonds, and topaz, but the quest for mineral wealth has led to much forest destruction.



Steel

South America's top steel maker, Brazil ranks highly in world production. This, and cheap labour, have attracted many car makers to invest in the country.



"Green" cars

About one-third of all Brazil's cars are run on so-called "green petrol", or ethanol, which is made from fermented sugar-cane. Because it produces less carbon monoxide than petrol when it is burned, it is less harmful to the environment and is reducing pollution.

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